

would be slower. In some cases when the virtualization software supports 3D acceleration to a huge extent (VMware Workstation is the best example), not being able to install the guest tools or add-ons is going to limit your experience quite a lot. Not only would you be unable to run any graphical software inside the VM, the overall experience would also be affected. Sometimes, these add-ons are also required to play audio inside your guest operating system.

Before downloading the virtualization software of your choice, ensure that both your guest as well as host operating systems are well supported by the software in terms of the guest add-ons.

Ease of use and shared folders

Shared folders are one of the most important features if you want to create files inside your guest machine and then copy them to your host operating system. Shared folders are usually dependent on correctly installed guest add-ons.

“Shared folders” is a feature which allows you to map a folder on your host operating system as a network drive (in case of a Windows guest operating system) or a mounted network directory (in case of a Linux guest operating system) in the guest operating system.

Without this feature, you'll have to rely on another USB drive which you'd connect to first copy files from the guest operating system to the USB drive and then unplug the drive and reconnect to copy files to the host operating system. This is a cumbersome process for two reasons:

1. You need to have the USB drive accessibility inside the guest OS, which in turn depends on the virtualization software.
2. The VM might make the USB drive unavailable to your host OS and attach it to one or more machines running as guests. In such a situation, you'd have to copy the file first, then shut down the guest OS, unplug the device and then reconnect it to copy files onto your host OS. Now that's what we can call the difficult way of doing things!

Before you go on with choosing the software of your choice for creating virtual machines, ensure that you have the shared folders feature to help you ease such operations.

Another factor which ensures ease of use is the display system. This too heavily depends on the guest add-ons. If they're not installed correctly, you might just be locked down to a maximum resolution of 1024x768 pixels inside the VM which is quite low for productive uses. Also, auto-capture